



political rules from carrying out full-scale strategic bombing, air forces could have a major impact on the progress of a conflict, but not a decisive one.

US nuclear bombers

The heavy losses suffered by the forces of the United States and its allies in Korea, and the failure to achieve a decisive victory there, led America to reassess its defense policy. Nuclear deterrence seemed to offer a more effective, and more cost-effective, way of blocking communist expansion than the threat of conventional warfare. Thus in the 1950s the central fact of military aviation was that aircraft constituted the major (and, at first, the only) delivery

system for the nuclear weapons that the United States had come to depend on for its defense.

Nuclear scientists on both sides of the Iron Curtain had no difficulty creating bigger and bigger bangs. The first hydrogen bomb, exploded in 1952, was 500 times more powerful than the device that had destroyed Hiroshima. But even the United States, with all its resources, took time to create an intercontinental bomber force for the nuclear age. In 1947 the Strategic Air

Command's potential nuclear strike force consisted of just 10 B-29 bombers. And it was widely accepted that the B-29 was not up to the job, in range, altitude, or speed.

“I believe we can get the B-36 over a target and not have the enemy know it is there until the bombs hit.”

GENERAL CURTISS LEMAY

HEAD OF THE US STRATEGIC AIR COMMAND

The process of finding a replacement bomber for the nuclear role was plagued by indecision and politics, centered around disputes as to which kind of bomber would work and whether what would work was worth the price. Boeing initially came up with the B-47, a seminal jet design with swept wings and the engines in pods on

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NUCLEAR GIANT

A group of mechanics stand on the horizontal stabilizer of the massive Convair B-36 nuclear bomber, one of the largest aircraft ever built. The rudder was as tall as a five-story building.